



Photograph Vinod Chandak

Each month *Digit* will carry a caption for a photo. Come up with something funnier, and beat the *Digit* team at their own game! Entries accepted by the 20th of this month.

Beat That!

Digit Caption

The number you have called is currently unreachable

Last Month's Winner!

V.K. Ramakrishna Chowdary,
Hyderabad
"Need a drive? Please insert driver"



E-mail your caption with the subject "Beat That", and your postal address, to beatthat@thinkdigit.com and win

Puzzles For Programmers and Pros
by Dennis E. Shasha



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behaviour (search query history) for statistical analysis and further utilisation in improving their algorithms.

The report from Article 29 of the Data Protection Working Party says that "search engine providers must delete or irreversibly anonymise personal data once they no longer serve the specified and legitimate purpose they were collected for". Hence, even if the data is collected through cookies, their lifetime shouldn't be significant. Also, the data should be used for personalised adverts, only if the user has consented for the same.

These data fields are anonymised by Yahoo after 13 months, while Google and MSN anonymise user data after 18 months. However, do these search engines safely anonymise your personal data when it can reveal critical information such as your location or service provider? The possibility of this data of yours being

misused does not go in your favour! Can you really be certain that the inferences of your search behaviour and pattern are not sold off to any advertising major?

Popularly referred to as stalking, search engines normally track user's search history by collecting their unique IP addresses and including a unique ID in cookies. Search engines collect information regarding search query patterns and results for billing the advertisers, through these very same cookies. Such comprehensive data with regard to different search patterns, queries, choice of results and user profile, which includes demographics is like a haven for advertising firms to bombard users with their ads.

The data could possibly be compromised or exploited. Also, the main issue is user's privacy, which must not be compromised under any cost, as per the EU panel.

No matter who you are or where you are from, no one should be allowed to fiddle around with user's privacy.

THE CHINESE CONNECTION

Becoming The Largest Online Population

According to latest news reports, China now not only boasts of the largest population, but also the highest number of Internet users. The China Network Information Centre has revealed that the number of Internet users in China is around 221 million. However, although this figure is now greater than the number of Internet users in US, the ratio of Internet users to the total population is still lower than the global average.

While the global average was 19.1 per cent, the Chinese stood at 16 per

cent. In the wake of online censorship and several other restrictions, these figures are more of an indication of the magnanimous Chinese population, rather than the IT development. Although, this might be a moment of pride, especially from an Asian point of view, India definitely is in a much better state, considering the online freedom and liberty that we enjoy as surfers, despite the lower Internet penetration in rural areas.

DIRECTING DISH

News Corp Alleged To Have Hired Hacker

A computer hacker has reportedly testified that he was hired by a News Corp unit to develop pirated software. The NDS Group, in which News Corp is the largest